Before Fergus

By Lynn Ferguson

LYNN: I'm Scottish. A friend of mine is Bosnian, and he married a Serbian, and together they had a child. They had to flee their country, because their child -- being of mixed race -- was in danger by just ***being***. They called their son Trim, which means "courage."

My friend said he called his son "Courage" because he felt that as soon as the child was born, he'd lost all of his own courage, and that anything that he'd fought for in his previous life had gone, and now he'd fight for nothing but the life of that child.

You know, I've thought about that a lot since I've had my son.

INTRODUCTION

Congratulations! You are expecting a baby! The time has come for the 20-week scan -- when names have been chosen, tummies are swelling and babies are kicking. The 20-week scan -- the opportunity to find out, will our child be a boy or a girl? But the 20-week scan is also called the "anomaly scan." Its intention is to determine if the baby is developing properly. You see, especially for women who conceive later in life, the risks of chromosomal birth defects exponentially increase.

In this selection, Lynn Ferguson is given a number of choices. Choices that will determine the fate of her family and her unborn child. Choices that, with the overturning of Roe v Wade, are no longer options for women in America. Lynn shares her personal stance on the issue of terminating a pregnancy: "I think it's a matter of choice . . . and I am completely and utterly pro-choice."

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LYNN: I was thirty-seven when I first fell pregnant. Well, I didn't ***fall*** pregnant. There wasn't some incident with a sidewalk and a flip-flop. I did stuff. I got pregnant. I was thirty-seven. The discovery wasn't the kind of romantic one you get in black-and-white movies. I had been touring France on the back of a motorcycle with my husband when I started to feel a bit unwell.

Now, a word of advice: if you're feeling sick, don't do it at eighty miles an hour, leather pants on one end, crash helmet on the other, in a country where they eat snails because they can.

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I've heard it said that you feel most like a woman when you're pregnant. It's complete rubbish. It's not so. I felt most like a beached whale. It's a completely bizarre thing, because you suddenly find yourself entirely responsible for this other person. And this other person has only got you, and so even though the two of you are together twenty-four hours a day, it's not like you can have a discussion about it.

Before I got pregnant, my greatest fear about getting run down by a car was that I wouldn't be wearing matching underwear. After I got pregnant, the whole idea of getting run over by a car took on a whole different meaning. Never mind the eating for two, it's the ***thinking*** for two that wears you out, you know?

There was a lot of difficulty around my pregnancy, because thirty-seven is considered quite an old age to be having your first child. So almost as soon as everybody agreed that I was in the family way, they decided that I should have an amniocentesis. An

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amniocentesis is an invasive test where they put a needle through the mother's belly and into the amniotic fluid, and it can tell you whether the baby has Down syndrome or not. But there's also a 1-percent risk that it will cause damage to the fetus or the fetus will miscarry.

Now, I'm totally not against risk; I think it's a matter of choice, and I like risk, and I am completely and utterly pro-choice. But there was no way they were going to do it. It wasn't the baby's fault I was thirty-seven. That was entirely on me. So, I was like, ***No.*** But every appointment it would come up, and initially I would deal with it that way you do when you don't want to have coffee with someone.

"Oh, the amniocentesis -- we will, we'll do it. I can't do it this week, though. Maybe next week? Oh, no, my mother's coming. No, I can't do that." But as they became more insistent about it, I kind of felt like I had to, too.

So, I was like, "You know, can this test tell me whether this child will be a jerk? Can your test tell

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me whether this kid is going to be one of those really screamy ones that annoys everybody on airplanes? Because I'm worried about Down syndrome, hands up, but I'm pregnant, and I'm worried about ***a lot*** of things. So, thanks very much and everything, but no."

Then came the twenty-week scan. We were told we were having a boy. Woo-hoo! Then the lady scanning the baby said that my son had statistically a very large head. I looked across at my husband for the first time, I swear, noticing ***his*** statistically large head. I silently cursed love for being blind.

She told me I was thirty-seven. I knew that.

Then, scanning the baby's head, she said there were choroid plexus cysts all down one side of the baby's brain. Okay. That wasn't something I was expecting. We were told that everything was going to be "fine," in that way where you just know it's not, and we had to wait for a specialist.

The specialist we went to see told us we were

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having a boy. We knew that. She told me I was thirty-seven. ***I know.*** She said the baby had a statistically large head. Then she said that the choroid plexus cysts were a problem. We'd kind of guessed that. And then, scanning the baby again, she said that there was a vessel missing on the umbilical cord.

She said we needed to do the test. But because I had waited so long, they didn't want to do an amnio, they wanted to do something called a cordio, which is pretty much the same as an amnio. They insert a big needle into the womb, and they take a little bit of the umbilical cord, and that can tell them what's going on with the baby. Now, this is an umbilical cord that they have just told me isn't fully functioning.

We didn't even need a discussion for the decision. I was like, "Okay, the Down syndrome thing, it's not exactly what we'd planned, and I know it's going to be difficult, probably -- for us and for him and in ways that I don't even know yet. But actually, per-

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sonally, I think there are worse things than having Down syndrome, you know? "I mean, having Down syndrome doesn't mean you're a bad person, does it?" So I said no.

But that's when they told me that Down syndrome was off the table and what we were talking about now was Edwards, a syndrome that means the baby will likely die, either in the womb or within the first year of life.

We'd had so many scans, and I'd seen my son. I'd seen his heart, seen the inside of his eyes. I'd seen his hands and his feet, and in fact, during one of the scans, he'd held his hand out to the front of my body as if to say, ***Will you go away? I'm busy. Do not disturb.***

I'd felt my son move inside my body. What did it matter whether he had a disorder or not? And if he was going to die, well, we're all going to die, right? So, we should meet first. He was my son, and he needed me. He was depending on me to make the right decision. So, I said no.

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We had no choice but to change hospitals after they offered me a termination at twenty-five weeks. It became really clear that they wanted to win a battle, and I just wanted to see my boy.

At precisely thirty-five weeks and five days, my son decided it was time to be born. My husband drove us to the hospital in our car, neither of us talking about what lay ahead.

The conversation was made up of the same four phrases: "Are you okay?" "Yeah." "You do know I love you?" "Yeah."

The birth process was the true definition of laborious. My husband gave me water and held my hand, and the midwives were brilliant. They were patient and reassuring. It would be okay, they said, everything was really early, but it would be okay.

I have no idea how long labor lasted, but eventually, my son appeared -- shot out, in fact, doing a kind of hand-brake turn on the table as he did so. He was purple in color, and my husband cut the cord. But

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whereas before there had been noise and bustle and shouting, suddenly there was silence. It was like the whole world had gone underwater.

The door burst open, and people in white coats came in. They bundled my son over onto a metal table, where they hurriedly tried to resuscitate him.

I had failed my son. He was depending on me, and I had failed him, and the whole world was underwater.

Then suddenly he choked, gagged, coughed up something, and started to breathe. The people in the white coats wandered off, and with my husband standing next to me, they handed me my son.

He. Was. Perfect.

"Fine," they said. "He's absolutely fine."

My son looked up at me. He was curious. He was amazing. He looked up at me as if to say, ***Ooh, that was all a bit* of *a trial.***

"I am so glad you're here," I said.

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My son is ten years old now, and he's still perfect (some of the time). And, like his father, he still has a statistically large head.

I haven't seen my Bosnian friend for such a long time, but I often wonder how he's getting on in his self-imposed exile. I called my son Fergus. In Irish it means "the right choice," but it has a different meaning in Scottish. It means "courage," too.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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